The Resume Bullet Formula

The exact structure I used to rewrite every bullet on my resume before landing 20+ interviews in two months. Three real before-and-afters, a verb bank, and a worksheet to rewrite your own bullets tonight.

The Formula: Google's X-Y-Z

Most resume bullets fail the same way. They sound impressive, they even have a number, but a recruiter reading them still can't tell what **you** actually did. Google's X-Y-Z formula fixes that by forcing three things into every bullet:

X

Accomplished X
The outcome. What got better because of your work.

Y

Measured by Y
The proof. A number, a percentage, a before and after.

Z

By doing Z
The thing you did. The tool, the method, the change you made.

Z is the part almost everyone skips. It's also the part that gets you interviews, because it's the only part that tells the hiring manager what you'd actually do for them. Anyone can be "part of" a team that improved retention. Z is what makes it clear you were the reason it improved.

> **You don't have to write it in X-Y-Z order.** Google's original version reads "Accomplished X, measured by Y, by doing Z." In practice, I flip it and start with the action (Z), then end on the result. The bullet opens with what I did and closes with the number. What matters is that all three parts are there.

3 Bullets That Sound Impressive and Say Nothing

1 The buzzword bullet

BEFORE

Led efforts to improve the customer onboarding experience by working closely with product, engineering, design, and analytics teams, resulting in a 20% increase in customer retention.

What's missing: "Led efforts" and "worked closely" don't say what you actually did. X and Y are there. Z isn't.

AFTER

Redesigned the customer onboarding flow using funnel analysis and user churn data, increasing 90-day customer retention by **20%**.

X	Y	Z
90-day retention went up	20%	Redesigned onboarding using funnel and churn data

2 The "sounds senior" bullet

BEFORE

Managed a cross-functional initiative focused on improving internal operational efficiency, helping reduce the average processing time for customer requests by 35%.

What's missing: Big words, same problem. What did you actually change?

AFTER

Automated the manual approval workflow using Python and internal APIs, cutting customer request processing time by **35%**.

X	Y	Z
Faster request processing	35%	Automated manual approvals with Python and internal APIs

Notice the word "helping." Words like helping, contributing to, and supporting make your role sound smaller than it was. If you did the work, say what you did.

3 The big shiny number

BEFORE

Developed and executed a new pricing strategy for enterprise customers that contributed to significant business growth and generated more than $200,000 in additional monthly revenue.

What's missing: This one is sneaky. $200K is catchy, but where did it come from? A great number doesn't replace Z.

AFTER

Launched a new enterprise pricing package after analyzing customer usage and willingness-to-pay data, generating **$200,000** in new monthly revenue.

X New monthly revenue	**Y** $200,000	**Z** Launched a pricing package based on usage and willingness-to-pay data

Start Every Bullet With an Action Verb

Look at how every rewrite starts: **redesigned, automated, launched.** The first word of a bullet should describe something you did, not a role you had. Here's a verb bank to steal from:

You built something
Built, Shipped, Launched, Designed, Redesigned, Created, Developed, Prototyped

You made something better
Cut, Reduced, Increased, Grew, Doubled, Accelerated, Simplified, Fixed

You changed how work gets done
Automated, Migrated, Standardized, Replaced, Consolidated, Rebuilt

You moved people or money
Negotiated, Closed, Hired, Mentored, Secured, Pitched, Convinced

Retire these openers. They describe being near the work, not doing it:

~~Responsible for~~ ~~Helped with~~ ~~Led efforts~~ ~~Worked closely with~~ ~~Participated in~~ ~~Assisted~~ ~~Contributed to~~

Make the Result Impossible to Miss

Bonus tip: I bold the impact numbers on my resume. The 20%, the 35%, the $200,000. Someone skimming your resume sees the result before anything else.

Don't have exact numbers? You still have options:

~ Tilde

Approximate honestly: **~30% fewer support tickets.**

Plain words

Use **doubled**, **tripled**, or **cut in half** when you know the size, not the decimal.

From → to

Show the change: **reduced from five days to two.**

One rule: only use a number you can explain in an interview. If someone asks "how did you measure that?", you should have an answer.

Rewrite Your Own

FILL IN THE BLANKS

[Action verb] [what you did] using **[tool, data, or method]**, **[result]** by **[number]**.

- [ ] Does it start with an action verb?
- [ ] Could a stranger tell what **you** did (is Z there)?
- [ ] Is there a number, an approximation, or a clear before and after?
- [ ] Is the number in bold?

YOUR BULLET, BEFORE

YOUR BULLET, AFTER

> A good resume bullet shouldn't just say something improved. It should make it obvious that *you* were the reason it improved.
>
> NIJAT · @NIJATCHATS